

Off the Shelf

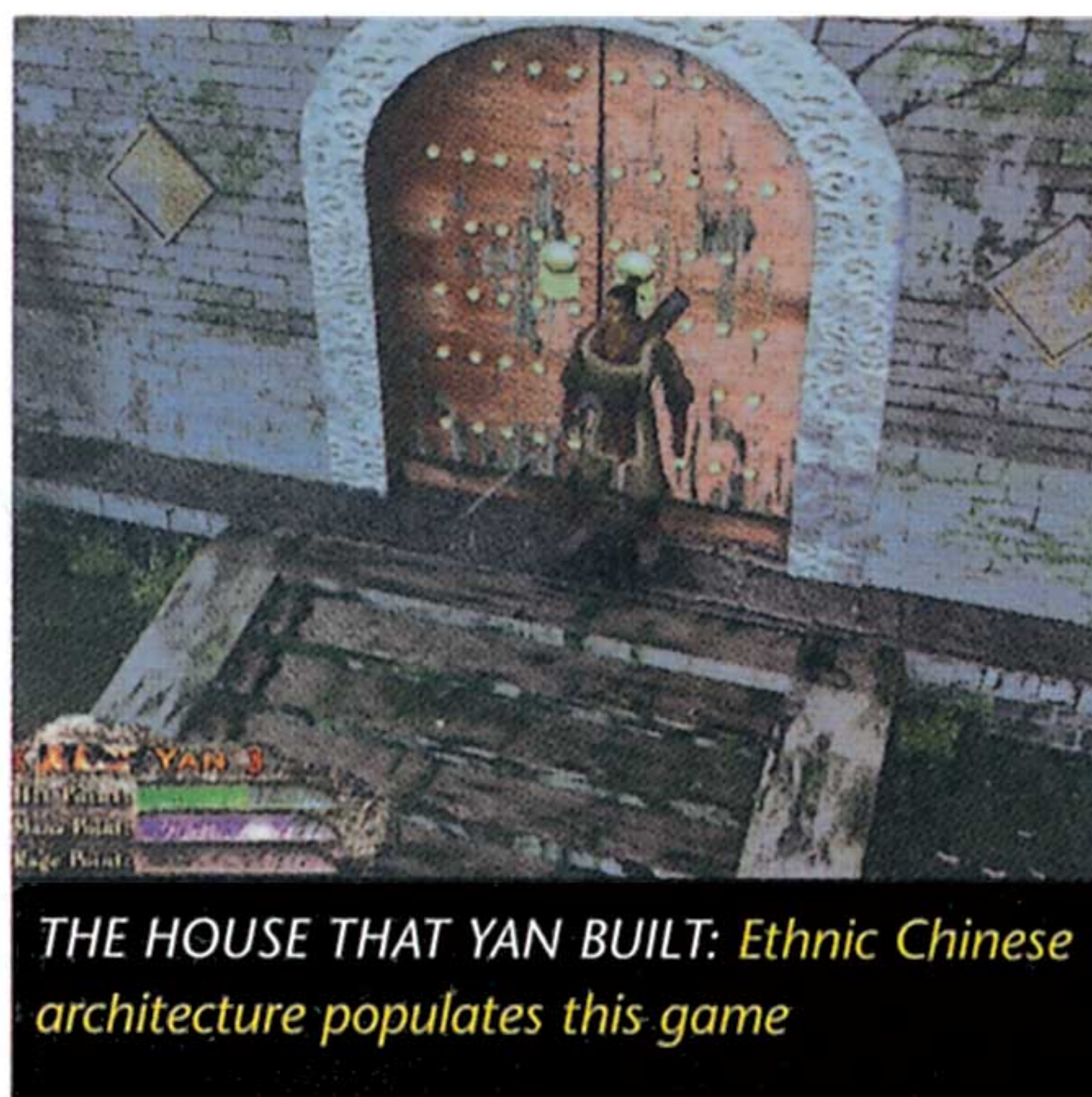


Ghost Temple

Your Kung fu is weak!

'*Ghost Temple* is a 3D horror adventure game, which is made on the basis of famous Chinese ancient gods and spirits stories', or so claims the installation CD for the game. In this action-adventure offering from X Game Works, China, you play as the Chinese warrior, Yan Chixia, who must defeat all the evil minions to rescue a princess. The introduction video gives you a brief background, but unless you understand Mandarin or comprehend the English, you pretty much spend your time figuring out what you are supposed to do.

The game features a fixed camera angle that doesn't track character movement, but instead switches views when the character moves out of view. Not only does such a view hinder freedom during combat, it also makes it hard to ascertain



THE HOUSE THAT YAN BUILT: *Ethnic Chinese architecture populates this game*

where your character is heading. The combat techniques are pretty ordinary, and you get the usual armoury of swords,

spells and fireballs. The graphics aren't much to write home about, though the backgrounds have been pre-rendered to perfection—this being the game's only saving grace.

Moving on to the AI, the enemies are commissioned just one move: hit hero, animate, wait around and repeat. They don't even bother coming after you if you run away. Instead, they very conveniently disappear the moment you get off their area and reappear when you return. There is no mouse support for motion and the backgrounds get very monotonous as the game progresses. Suffice to say, this game would have been acceptable if it were made in the 1980s. So unless you're still stuck in the last century, pass this one and head for the Chinese noodles instead.

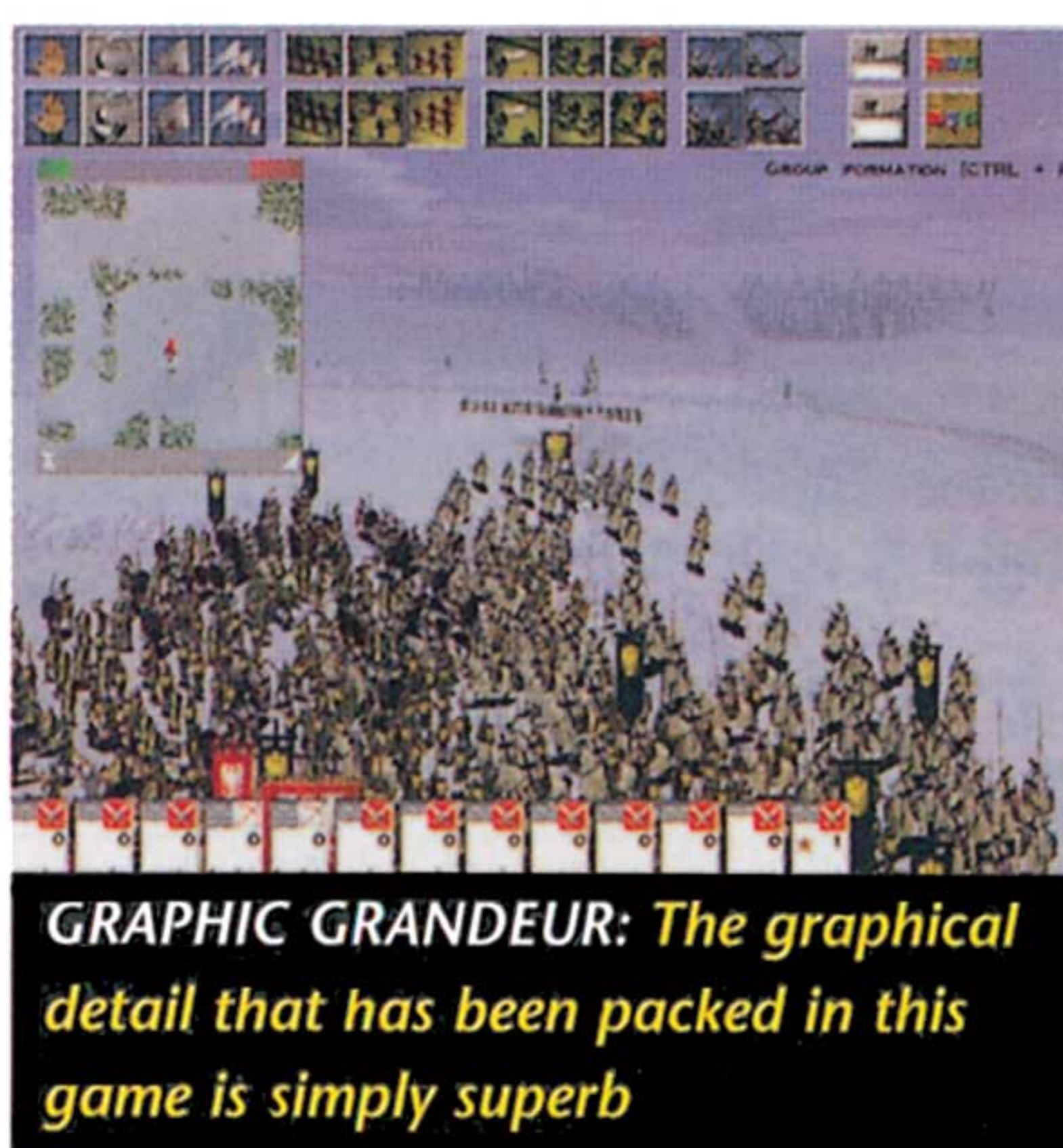
Minimum System Requirements: Pentium II 266 MHz, 64 MB RAM, 1.2 GB hard disk space, 4 MB videocard ■ **Genre:** Action-Adventure
Developer: X Game Works ■ **Distributor:** Aladdin Multimedia Pvt Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-7895085/7903959 ■ **Web site:** www.xgameworks.com/english/product/ghost/index.htm ■ **Price:** Rs 490 ■ **Rating:** ★★★★★



Medieval: Total War

Total fun

As the title indicates, *Medieval: Total War* is set in the medieval ages and has its helpings of knights, jihadis and commoners. The highlight of the whole game is its interface. Featuring full-blown 3D graphics, the game is played and viewed in third



GRAPHIC GRANDEUR: *The graphical detail that has been packed in this game is simply superb*

person perspective. A standard 2D overview map lets you keep an eye on the big picture while focusing on a portion of the battle. The in-game gothic tunes and drum rolls add to the war and strife even as the hooves of your cavalry thunder across the screen.

In the single player missions, you have to choose a campaign—each

faction has particular traits that change the way a battle must be fought. Factors such as cost of living, agility, aggressiveness, etc, have been carefully factored to make campaigns nation-specific. There's even a Grand Achievement campaign in which you get to duplicate the feats from history. The multiplayer mode is just as fun with friends and foes joining the battle.

The effort has been to maintain a sense of historical structure, without letting history get in the way of a good time—and the game achieves that admirably.

Minimum System Requirements: P-II 350 MHz, 128 MB RAM, 1.7 GB hard disk space, 16 MB 3D accelerator card ■ **Genre:** Strategy
Developer: Creative Assembly ■ **Distributor:** Milestone Interactive ■ **Phone:** 022-8381614 ■ **Web site:** www.totalwar.com ■ **Price:** Rs 1,999
Rating: ★★★★★